

VOLUME ONE

Reclaiming the Land

Sankt Annen, 1901–1918

The Reclaimed Land

A North Sea Saga



aban news

Novel · written with Claude Opus

The Reclaimed Land - Reclaiming the Land

Drama / Family and Social Novel

aban news

geschrieben mit Claude Opus · aban news

. . .

Chapter 1 - The New Dyke-Reeve

They elected Hauke Carstens dyke-reeve on a March day in 1901, and there were those in the koog who thought him too young for it, thirty-one, and did not say so aloud but only saw it, the way in the marshland one sees everything and says little. Hauke knew it. He saw it in the faces as he stepped out of the inn into the wet March air, and he took it with him, the way he took everything, without expression. The land lay flat beneath the sky, so flat that the sky was the greater thing and the land only a dark line beneath it. Whoever grew up here learned early that there was no above to hold to, only the wide expanse and the wind that came from the west and never quite stopped. Over the marsh the dwelling-mounds lay like islands, the warften, artificial hills onto which the farmsteads had been set, high enough that the water would not reach them at flood tide, and on the largest mound of the Sankt-Annen-Koog stood the Carstens farm, as it had for four generations, and Hauke was the fifth.

The day after the election he walked the dyke with old Okke Nissen, who had been dyke-warden as long as Hauke could remember. Okke was a bony man with a face like untanned leather, and he walked slowly, with the deliberateness of one who knows the dyke does not run off and neither does the water. They walked on the crown of the dyke, and to their right lay the won land, the marsh, fat and fertile, with its ditches and sluice-drains, and to their left lay the water, grey and patient, behind the foreland and the brushwood groynes that had been built out into it to wrest the silt from the sea.

"There," said Okke, and pointed with his chin at a spot at the dyke's foot where the grass grew differently, darker, more lush. "There the water stands too long. It seeps through. You must remember that, Hauke. The dyke talks, if you listen. The grass tells you where it grows tired."

Hauke looked. He saw it now that Okke showed it: the darker line, the rich green that meant nothing good, for here only what had too much water grew lush. "What does it cost to put right?"

Okke looked at him from the side, and in the leathery face something moved that was almost a smile and never became one. "That's what you ask first. What it costs." He walked on. "Your father always asked the price first too. And your grandfather. It's the question of the Carstenses."

"It's a reasonable question."

"It's a reasonable question," said Okke. "Until it isn't."

They walked the whole dyke, three hours, and Okke showed him everything, every spot where the mountain — that was what the old people called the dyke, the mountain, as if there were mountains up here — every spot where the mountain was weak, where it held, where they had patched last year. Hauke listened and remembered it all, for that was what a dyke-reeve had to be able to do: know the dyke like his own body, every spot, every weakness, every cracking. The office was not an honour, even if the people called it so. The office was responsibility for the lives of all who lived behind the dyke, and whoever forgot that learned it in the first heavy tide.

At home, on the warft, Antje was waiting. She stood in the doorway of the great farmhouse, one hand at the small of her back, for the first child was on the way, and she watched him come up the mound path, slowly, with the gait of one who has been three hours on

the dyke. She did not say she was glad. She said: "How does the dyke stand?"

"It stands," said Hauke. "At one spot the water stands too long. By the sluice. Okke wants me to put it right."

"Then put it right."

"It costs."

Antje looked at him, and her gaze was clear and without detour, as it always was, and Hauke had learned that this gaze saw more than he liked. "Everything costs," she said. "A dead man costs more." She stepped aside and let him in, into the warmth of the farmhouse, into the smell of cattle and peat and boiled cabbage, and Hauke went in, and outside, behind the dyke, the water rose to the flood, as it rose twice a day, as it had since the world began, and sank again, patient, and each time took a little silt and laid down a little silt, and no one could see by looking what it intended.

In the night Hauke lay awake and listened to the water. You could hear it, when the wind stood right, the working of the tide at the sluice, a sucking and pressing, and Hauke lay and heard it and reckoned. He reckoned what the spot by the sluice would cost, done properly, with new clay and faggots, and he reckoned what it cost to patch it, cheaply, for this year. And he thought that a heavy tide came rarely, every ten, every twenty years, and that one could put right a great deal by then, and that the money saved now would benefit the farm, the child that was coming. He thought that, and he knew at the same time that Okke was right, that it was a reasonable question, until it wasn't. But the tide was far off, and the child was near, and Hauke fell asleep before he had decided, and believed he had decided nothing.

. . .

Chapter 2 - The Neighbour

Momme Feddersen had stood for the office of dyke-reeve, and he had not got it, and that lay between the two men, whether they named it or not. They did not name it. They worked side by side on the dyke, as they had worked side by side for years, for the Feddersen warft lay nearest to the Carstens warft, and in the marshland the nearest neighbour was the thing a life hung on when the water came. Momme was four years older than Hauke and broader, a man with hands like spades and a feel for the water that Hauke secretly admired and did not let show. Momme could read the dyke like no other, almost better than Okke, for Okke read it with the experience of years and Momme with something innate, an instinct for the spot where the mountain would give way. If the election had gone by who knew the dyke best, Momme would have had the office. But the election did not go by that. It went by the farm, the name, the land, and the Carstenses had more land and an older name, and so Hauke became dyke-reeve and Momme stayed what he was: a good man on the dyke who served under a younger one.

One day in the first summer they worked together on the groynes, out in the foreland, where one wrested the silt from the water. One stuck rows of brushwood fences into the watt floor, scrub between posts, and the water left its silt in them at each flood, and over the years new land grew from the sea, centimetre by centimetre, until one could dyke it in. It was patient work, work for generations, and Hauke liked it, because it was the only thing that won from the water instead of the other way round.

They stood knee-deep in the silt, and the flood came, faster than Hauke had thought, for the water in the watt always came faster than one thought; it did not come from in front, it came from everywhere, filled the channels, the runnels, cut off one's way back before one noticed. Hauke felt the ground beneath him soften, felt the suck as he tried to lift a foot and could not, and for a moment there was the cold clarity of danger, the knowledge that the watt swallowed people, every year, who misjudged the channel.

Momme was at him in three strides. He had firm ground beneath him, somehow, with the feel he had, and he gripped Hauke by the arm and pulled him out, out of the soft ground, onto the groyne, onto firm footing. It went quickly and without words, and then they both stood on the brushwood, and the water rose around them, and Momme looked at him and grinned, the broad grin that fit so badly with his usual reticence.

"Dyke-reeve," said Momme. "Mind you don't drown before you've warmed your office chair."

"Thank you," said Hauke.

"Nothing to thank." Momme let go of his arm. "Out here it doesn't count who holds the office. Out here it counts only who holds your arm when the channel takes you. One forgets that easily, up on the dyke, with the book and the inspection. But the water reminds you." He looked out, where the flood overran the groynes. "We hang together, Hauke. All of us. That's the only thing that holds us against that out there. Not the dyke. The dyke is only earth. What holds us is that no one lets the other drown."

It was a long speech for Momme Feddersen, who otherwise said little, and Hauke remembered it, the way he remembered everything. Solidarity, a man from the city would have called it. Momme did not

call it that. He did not call it anything; he only did it, pulled a man's arm from the silt and said there was nothing to thank. And Hauke, standing wet and shivering on the groyne while the flood rose around them, thought that he now owed this man his life, and that such a debt did not grow smaller with time but larger, and he did not know that one day he would think back on this day, in the storm, in the night, when the same water that Momme defeated today would take him.

On the way home, over the dyke, they looked across to the Carstens warft and to the Feddersen warft, which was smaller, poorer, nearer the water. Antje and Momme's wife stood together at the sluice-drain doing the washing, and their voices carried across the flat land, and Hauke thought that the women had it easier with the neighbourliness than the men, because between them stood no office and no land, only the work that all shared. He was wrong, but he did not know that on this day.

. . .

Chapter 3 - Dyke Duty

The dyke inspection was in spring, and it was the thing that held the koog together and divided it at once. On a day in May the inspection walked the dyke, the dyke-reeve at the front, then the sworn dyke-men, then the farmers, each responsible for his section, for so it had been arranged from of old: each farm had its stretch of dyke to maintain, according to the size of its land, and whoever let his stretch decay was punished, and in the worst case lost his land. Spadelandsrecht it was called, the old law of the marsh, and the saying that went with it was hard and simple and hung over every koog like the weather: whoever will not dyke must yield. Hauke led his first inspection, and he led it strictly, for a new dyke-reeve who was not strict counted for nothing. He walked every section and saw every spot and wrote down what was to be put right, and the farmers followed and grumbled quietly, for every spot the dyke-reeve wrote down was work and money they had to raise. So the system was: the safety of all was paid for by each one alone, and each reckoned what the safety cost him, and none reckoned what the unsafety would cost him, for the unsafety was far off and the money was near.

At the faulty spot by the sluice the inspection halted. It was the spot Okke had shown him in March, the darker grass, the seeping water, and now, in May, one saw more: the clay had grown loose, there were mouse-runs, and at one place, when one stabbed with the spade, the water came up from below, where none should be.

"That must be done properly," said Okke, loud enough for the inspection to hear. "Not patched. Done. New clay, dug out to the firm ground, built up anew. That's two weeks' work and costs what it costs."

Hauke stood before the spot and reckoned. He reckoned in his head, fast, as he always reckoned: two weeks' work, ten men, the clay, the faggots, and that in spring, when the fields needed hands, when every day on the dyke was a day the land lacked. It was much. It was more for this one section than was needed for the whole rest of the dyke.

"We patch it for this year," said Hauke. "And do it properly in autumn, after the harvest, when the hands are free."

Okke looked at him, long, and said nothing. But Momme Feddersen, who stood in the inspection for his section, he said something. "In autumn the tide season has begun," he said. "In autumn and winter the heavy floods come, not in summer. If you do it in autumn, you may do it too late."

"It holds till autumn," said Hauke. "Patched, it holds an ordinary tide."

"And one that isn't ordinary?"

"That doesn't come every autumn, Momme."

"No," said Momme. "It doesn't come every autumn. It comes once in twenty years. But when it comes, it comes at the spot you patched and did not do. That's how the water is. It seeks out the spot where you saved money."

It went quiet in the inspection. The farmers looked from Momme to Hauke and back, and Hauke felt that more was being negotiated than a stretch of dyke. It was about the office, about the authority of the new dyke-reeve, and if he now gave way before Momme

Feddersen, who had wanted the office himself, then he had lost as dyke-reeve before he had begun.

"We patch it," said Hauke once more, firmly, and it was meant to sound firm and sounded defiant. "And do it in autumn. That is my word as dyke-reeve."

Momme looked at him, and in his face there was no triumph and no anger, only a kind of regret that was worse than both. He nodded slowly. "Your word as dyke-reeve," he said. "Good. But write in your book that I warned. That the spot won't hold what you credit it with."

"Write it in the book, Okke," said Hauke, and it was meant to sound firm and sounded petulant.

And Okke, who kept the dyke book, the old book in which one had entered for a hundred years what happened at the dyke, Okke wrote it in the book. He wrote the faulty spot by the sluice, wrote that it had been patched and not done, wrote that a warning had been given. Hauke watched him write, saw the pen go across the paper, and he said nothing, and in him was a feeling he did not want to name, something between defiance and a first, distant unease. The inspection moved on, along the dyke, and behind them stayed the spot, patched for this year, and the entry in the book, black on white, and the water that lay before it, grey and patient, and remembered where one had saved.

. . .

Chapter 4 - The Faulty Spot

Autumn came, and with it the harvest, and the harvest bound all hands, as Hauke had foreseen and secretly hoped. It was a good year, a full one, the corn stood heavy, and one could not harvest and dig at the dyke at once, everyone saw that, that was no idleness, that was the reason of the marsh. So the spot by the sluice was not done, not in autumn, not properly, as Hauke had promised before the inspection. It stayed as it was, patched, and Hauke told himself one would do it the next spring, certainly, first of all, before anything else. But Momme Eddarsen did not forget the spot. He went there, of his own accord, on a day in October, and looked at it, and that evening he came to Hauke on the warft, which he rarely did, and stood in the doorway of the farmhouse, his cap in his hand, and said: "The spot is getting worse."

"It's harvest time, Momme."

"The harvest is nearly in. In two weeks the hands are free." Momme took a step inside, and the lamplight fell on his face, which was serious, more serious than usual. "Hauke, I'm not telling you this because I wanted the office and didn't get it. That's over, I don't hold it against you. I'm telling you because I've seen the spot. The water comes through now already, at an ordinary tide. The clay won't hold any more. If a heavy tide comes, this winter, it'll break there. Not somewhere else. There."

Hauke stood at the table, and Antje sat by the hearth and listened without looking up, and sewed, and Hauke felt that she was listening, and that made it worse. "We'll do it in spring," he said. "Properly. I

promise you."

"In spring the tide season is over. In spring it's easy to do it, because the danger is past. That's no art, Hauke." Momme looked at him, and in his gaze there was now something hard. "The art is to do it now, before the winter, where it's difficult and expensive and where the hands are needed elsewhere. That's the office. Not the easy spot at the easy time. The hard one at the hard time."

"I'm the dyke-reeve, Momme."

"Yes," said Momme. "You are." He put his cap back on. "Then decide as dyke-reeve. But don't decide for your farm. Decide for the koog. That's the difference, and you'll learn it, one way or another." He nodded to Antje, curtly, and went out into the autumn night, and Hauke heard his steps fade across the mound path.

For a while it was quiet in the farmhouse. Then Antje said, without looking up, without stopping the needle: "He's right."

"It costs two weeks' work, now, when —"

"He's right, Hauke. You know it. You know it better than he does, for you have the book and the inspection and the responsibility. You know the spot won't hold. And you don't do it, because it's expensive and because the tide may not come." Now she looked up, and her gaze met his, clear and without mercy. "May not. You're staking the koog on a may-not. That's what you're doing."

"A heavy tide comes once in twenty years."

"And if it comes this year?"

Hauke had no answer to that, and that was the answer. He went to the door and looked out, into the night, across the flat land toward the dyke one did not see, only sensed, and behind it the water one heard when the wind stood. He thought: If I do the spot now, I give Momme the right of it, then the passed-over man has schooled the

new dyke-reeve, before the whole koog, for the whole koog would know. And he thought: If I don't do it and it goes well, then I've saved money and kept my authority. And if it does not go well — but that he did not think to the end. He left the thought at the edge, where it did not hurt, the way one leaves an entry in the book at the edge, unread.

"In spring," he said once more, quietly, more to himself than to Antje.

Antje said nothing more. She sewed on, and the child in her, that would come soon, kicked against her hand, and she laid her hand a moment on her belly, and Hauke saw it and turned away. Outside the wind went through the night, from the west, and carried up the working of the tide, the sucking and pressing at the sluice, at the spot that had not been done, and no one slept well that night on the Carstens warft, and outside, in the dark, the water came and went and remembered, tide by tide, where the man had saved.

. . .

Chapter 5 - The Spring Tide

The winter of 1906 came early and hard, and at the beginning of December the wind turned to northwest and stayed there. That was the dangerous thing, not the storm alone, but the wind that stood, day after day, for a standing northwest pressed the water of the North Sea into the bight, pressed it against the coast, higher and higher, and when then a spring tide came as well, the high tide at new or full moon, the water piled up over all the marks one knew. Okke Nissen read the weather like a book, and on a day in December he came to the Carstens warft, without his cap, his thin hair in the wind, and his leathery face was grey. "One's coming," he said. "A heavy one. The wind's stood four days, and the day after tomorrow is spring tide. That'll give one such as we haven't had in a long time."

Hauke felt the cold come over him, and it was not the wind. "How high?"

"Higher than the marks. How high, only the water knows. But high." Okke looked at him. "The spot by the sluice, Hauke."

"I know."

"It won't hold that."

"I know, Okke." Hauke said it sharply, more sharply than he meant, and Okke only nodded and said no more, for what was there to say now. Now it was too late to do the spot; one could not in two days, in this weather, properly mend a dyke section. One could only watch it, in the night, with men and sandbags and faggots, and hope it held, or, if it gave way, prevent the worst.

Hauke called up the whole koog. That was the right and the duty of the dyke-reeve: at a threatening storm tide every man had to come to the dyke, every one, without exception, for a breach hit all. They came, in the dusk of the storm day, with spades and lanterns, in oilskins, and Hauke divided them, section by section, and it was a strange hour, in which the whole koog stood at the dyke, rich and poor, Carstens and Feddersen and all the others, united against the one thing that threatened them all.

He divided the watches, and when he came to the spot by the sluice, the faulty spot, he needed a man who understood the water, one who would recognise when it grew critical, one to whom one could entrust the most dangerous spot. And without long thought, half from reason, half from something else he did not admit to himself, he said: "Momme. You take the spot by the sluice. You know it. You know what to watch for."

Momme looked at him. It was a long look, and in it lay much: the knowledge that this was the most dangerous spot; the knowledge that Hauke had been warned and not heeded; and something like bitterness, that now of all men he should guard the spot he had warned against. "The spot I said would break," said Momme.

"It holds best if there's one there who knows it."

"Or it takes the one who's there." Momme said it without reproach, almost calmly, a statement. Then he took his spade. "Good. I'll take the spot." He went there, through the storm, to the faulty spot by the sluice, and Hauke watched him go, and in him was a pull he did not want to name.

Antje, hauling sandbags with the other women, had heard the assignment. She came to Hauke, the kerchief tight around her head, and said into his ear, against the storm: "You're sending Momme to

the spot."

"He knows it best."

"You're sending him to the spot you know can break." She looked at him, and in her eyes was something Hauke had never seen there before, a fright that went deeper than the fear of the flood. "Hauke."

"It's the best assignment," said Hauke, and it did not sound convinced, and Antje heard it. But there was no time left, for the flood rose, faster now, and the gauge at the sluice already stood over the first mark, and rose further, over the second, and the wind howled across the dyke and tore the words from the men's mouths, and the water came, grey and black and higher than anything the living knew, and pressed against the dyke, against the spot that had not been done, and Momme Feddersen stood before it, with his lantern, alone in the storm, and guarded it.

. . .

Chapter 6 - The Breach

It happened in the third hour after midnight, when the tide reached its peak, and it happened as Momme had foretold: at the spot by the sluice, not somewhere else. Hauke was at his own section, a stretch further on, and he heard it sooner than he saw it. It was a sound he never forgot, though it nearly drowned in the storm: a sagging, a dull giving-way of the earth, and then the water, which no longer pressed but streamed, with a roar that was different from the roar of the storm, deeper, greedier. The dyke had given way. The mountain had broken.

Hauke knew at once where. He knew it without looking, with the certainty of one who knew the spot, who had been warned, who had seen the entry in the book. The spot by the sluice. Momme's spot. He let the spade fall and ran, against the storm, along the dyke crown, and his heart beat in his throat, and he prayed, without knowing he prayed, that it was not so bad, that Momme had drawn back in time, that no one —

He came to the spot. In the light of the few lanterns still burning he saw the breach: the dyke was torn away over twenty metres, and through the gap the water shot into the koog, a black, roaring stream that swept everything with it. And in the water, in the breach, in the whirling, roaring dark, he saw Momme for a moment. He saw him struggle, saw the arms, saw the face that looked up to him, and then the water tore him away, into the koog, into the darkness, and Hauke saw him no more.

"Momme!" Hauke cried it into the storm, and the storm took it from his mouth. He wanted to go down, into the breach, into the water, but hands held him fast, Okke's hands, other hands, for whoever climbed into that breach was lost, the water was too strong, swept everything with it, and a dead dyke-reeve saved no one.

"You can't!" Okke cried into his ear. "You can't go after him! The water takes you too!"

They held him, and Hauke stood on the breaking dyke and watched the water stream into his koog, into the land he was to have secured, through the spot he had not had done. Below, in the koog, the lights went out, one farm after another, as the water reached them; one heard the cattle bellow, heard cries, far off, in the storm. The warften became islands, one after another, and the water rose in the land, where no water should be, and Hauke stood and watched it and could do nothing, nothing more, for what should have been done one would have had to do in autumn, or in spring, or on the day the inspection halted before the spot and Okke said it must be done, not patched.

The night was long. They saved what they could, pulled people from roofs and from the rising water, drove cattle onto the warften, hauled bags into the breach that the water tore out again. The Carstens warft held; it lay high and far from the breach, and Antje and the maids brought the cattle into the farmhouse and stoked fires and cooked for those who arrived soaked and half-frozen. But the lower warften, nearer the breach, filled up, and the Feddersen warft, the smallest, the poorest, lay in the midst of the new water, and by morning of it one saw only the roof.

When the first grey light crept over the flooded land, Hauke stood at the edge of the breach, through which the water now streamed

more slowly, because the level inside the koog and outside had equalised. They had not found Momme. They would find him later, in the silt, a stretch inland, where the water had carried him. Hauke stood and looked over the land that had become a sea, grey water to the horizon, out of which the warften rose like the backs of drowning animals, and he knew, with a clarity that made him colder than the storm, why the spot had broken, and who had guarded it, and that the two were connected, and that he would never be able to make it not have happened, all his life.

Okke stepped beside him. The old man said nothing for a long time. Then he said, quietly, so only Hauke heard: "The book, Hauke. It's in there. That the spot wasn't done. That a warning was given."

Hauke did not answer. He looked over the water, and in him formed, before he even thought it, the first line of what he would do, what he would not do, what he would say and not say. And Okke, who had turned his leathery face into the grey, waited to see if the dyke-reeve would say something, and the dyke-reeve said nothing, and in that silence, on the morning after the flood, over the drowned land, the other thing began, the thing that would last longer than any flood.

. . .

Chapter 7 - An Act of God

The authority came from the county town, three days after the flood, when the water was slowly beginning to run off again, through the breach and through the sluices, and the land emerged from the sea once more, muddy, devastated, with dead animals and broken fences and a thick layer of silt over everything. A hydraulic inspector came and an official from the district administrator, and they recorded the breach, as one recorded such breaches: soberly, measuring, with the wish to find what they sought. A spring tide at standing northwest, a level that exceeded all known marks, a force of nature against which no dyke in the world was safe. An act of God. That was the formula, and it fit, for it was half true: the tide had really been exceptional, the level really beyond all marks. That the dyke broke at precisely the weakest spot, at the spot one knew and had not done — that could be explained otherwise too, and the inspector, who did not know the koog, had no reason to ask otherwise.

Hauke gave his statement. He gave it as dyke-reeve, terse, in firm sentences, and he told the truth, as far as it served him. He said the tide had exceeded all marks. He said the dyke had been in proper condition after the last inspection. He said one had done what was possible. What he did not say — and only Antje, who was permitted to be present because she was the dyke-reeve's wife, heard the silence around this one spot — was that he had known of the weakness by the sluice. That Okke had advised a thorough repair. That Momme had warned, twice, three times. That there was an entry in the dyke

book. He said nothing of it, and the concealing was no lie in the strict sense, for no one asked him; it was only the leaving-out of what would have struck him, and that was almost worse, because it was so easy.

Then it was Okke's turn. Okke Nissen, the dyke-warden, who kept the dyke book in which the entry stood. The inspector asked him about the condition of the dyke, and Okke, who could not lie and would not lie, said the dyke was old and at many a spot tired, as every dyke was. The inspector asked whether there had been known weak spots. And Okke —

Okke was silent a moment too long. Hauke saw it, saw the old man wrestle, saw how the knowledge lay on his tongue, the entry, the warning, the faulty spot. One word, and it would have been out, and Hauke would have been a man of acts of God no longer, but a dyke-reeve who out of thrift had not done a spot at which a man drowned. One word.

Okke said: "Weak spots, every dyke has. You inspect them, you patch them. More a man cannot do against the water." He did not look at Hauke as he said it. He looked at his hands, the old, spotted hands that had kept the book, and he did not lie, for what he said was true — and he did not say the whole truth, for he named neither the entry nor the warning nor the one spot. It was loyalty, perhaps. It was fear, perhaps, of what it meant to accuse the dyke-reeve, to split the koog in a time when the koog had to hold together to survive. It was the reason of the marsh, which made silence cheaper than speech. Whatever it was, Okke now carried it too, and with him the dyke book, in which the truth stood black on white and which no one opened.

Momme's death was recorded as an accident in the dyke service. A brave man, it said, who did his duty at an endangered spot and was taken by the water. It was true, every word, and it left out the one thing: that the spot was endangered because one had not done it, and that the one who knew this was the man who had stationed him there. Momme's widow received a small compensation, as was due to the bereaved, and the authority departed, and the koog stayed with its devastation and its dead man and its formula: an act of God.

In the evening, when it was all over, Hauke and Antje sat in the parlour, and neither said anything. Then Antje looked at him, long, and in her gaze there was no accusation, but something heavier: the knowledge that they now belonged together, more firmly than by the marriage certificate, welded together by what he had done and concealed and she had not prevented. She could have stood up, could have gone to the authority, could have named the entry in the book. She did not. She stood up, stoked the fire, hung the pot over it, and said: "Eat. It was a long day." And that was her part of the silence, her own, and they laid it together over what had happened, the way the water laid the silt over the devastated land, thick and smooth and covering everything.

. . .

Chapter 8 - Who Dykes, Gains

The koog had to be dyked in again, and Hauke did it, with an energy that was almost obsession. He was everywhere, from the first day: organised the closing of the breach, procured clay and faggots, divided the men, worked himself, to exhaustion. The people saw it and said the young dyke-reeve took the flood to heart, he worked as if he wanted to make the disaster un-happen with his own hands, and that did him credit. They did not know that they were right, only differently than they meant: Hauke worked against something that could not be worked away, and the more he worked, the less it helped. ~~They closed the breach and they made the dyke higher and stronger than it had been, higher than the new mark the flood of 1906 had set.~~ That was the lesson the koog drew from every flood: one built the dyke to the last flood, always one flood too late, for the next would be higher again, that was the old game between the human and the water, a game the human never won and never quite lost.

And then came the new survey. For a part of the land could not be reclaimed, at least not at once. The deepest stretch of the koog, where the breach had been and the water had stood longest, stayed wet, salted, useless, and it was decided to lead the new dyke a stretch inland and leave this deepest stretch outside for now, to the water, as foreland. It was a sensible decision, a technical one, and it had a consequence no one said aloud: in this abandoned stretch lay the Feddersen warft. Momme's farm. His land.

So the Feddersen widow lost what had remained to her. The farm was flooded anyway, the warft half washed away, but the land that belonged to it, which now lay outside the new dyke, that was worth nothing any more, was foreland, given over to the water. And through the same survey the Carstens farm gained: land that had once bordered the Feddersens fell now, through the new dyke line, to the Carstens side, to Hauke's farm. It was no intention, Hauke told himself, it was the geography, the technology, the most sensible line for the new dyke. And yet the result was that Hauke gained where Momme died, that his farm grew larger out of the flood that his spot had broken.

Hauke tried to help the widow. He sent her corn, secretly, through a maid, and money, anonymously, he thought. The widow sent the corn back. She came herself, on a winter day, across the muddy mound path, a woman who had aged twenty years in one night, and she set the sack of corn before Antje's door and said, when Antje opened: "We take nothing from the house of Carstens." She said it calmly, almost toneless. "My husband stood at your spot. At the spot he warned of. You know that, Antje Carstens. You know it as well as I do." And she went, without another word, and left the sack standing, and Antje picked it up and closed the door and said nothing, and from that day the women did not greet each other, who had once washed together at the sluice.

The widow knew, then. Perhaps Momme had told her, before the flood, of the warning and the not-being-heard; perhaps she knew it only with the certainty of women who read their men's silences like the weather. She had no proof, as little as Antje had proof, as little as little Thies Feddersen, Momme's son, who was now fatherless and impoverished. But she knew, and her knowing was an accusation that

weighed the more because it never came to court, but lived only in a returned sack of corn, in an unreturned greeting, in the knowledge of two families that would inherit like the land itself.

At night Antje laid her hand on Hauke's back, in the dark, and Hauke lay awake and listened to the water, which now stood behind a higher dyke, further off, but not gone, never quite gone. He had gained. His farm was larger, his dyke stronger, his office secured, for a dyke-reeve who rebuilt so vigorously after the flood counted for something. He had gained everything there was to gain, and he knew he had lost it, in the same moment he gained it, and that no higher dyke and no larger land ever again balanced this one reckoning.

. . .

Chapter 9 - The Boy at His Hand

Bo was born two years after the flood, in 1908, in a mild spring, and at first Hauke saw in the child only what every father sees in his firstborn: the continuation, the heir, the one for whom one worked. Only later, as the boy grew, did he see other things, and it frightened him. Bo grew up on the warft, in the shadow of the dyke, and like all marsh children he learned early to read the water. Hauke took him along on the dyke, as Okke had once taken him, and showed him what a Carstens had to know: where the dyke was strong and where tired, how to read the grass, how to read the gauge at the sluice. The boy learned fast, faster than others, and he learned with a seriousness, a doggedness, that was not childlike. Bo wanted to do everything right, wanted to be the best, and Hauke recognised the ambition, because it was his own, the same hunger for standing, the same need to be something in this flat, hard land.

And Hauke feared him. He feared the ambition in his own son, because he knew where it could lead: to the faulty spot one does not do because it is expensive; to the sensible thrift that is no longer thrift but a gamble with the lives of others. He saw it sprouting in the boy and could say nothing against it, for the only thing he would have had to say — beware where your ambition drives you, I know it, I followed it, and a man died of it — that he could not say, never.

Thies Feddersen, Momme's son, was a few years older than Bo. After the flood the Feddersens were impoverished; the land before the dyke was worthless, the warft destroyed, the widow scraped by

on the little that remained. And when Thies was old enough, he had to go to work, and there was hardly work for an impoverished boy except at the larger farms, and the largest farm nearby was the Carstenses'. So it came about that Thies Feddersen started as a herd-boy at Hauke's, at the man at whose faulty spot his father had drowned.

It was a humiliation no one spoke of and all saw. The son of the drowned Momme herded the cattle of the dyke-reeve who had not had the spot done. Hauke gave him good wages, more than usual, and it helped nothing, made it worse if anything, for everyone in the koog understood what these good wages were: an atonement that did not speak its name, a guilt-money that bore no name. Thies took the wages, because his mother needed them, and he took them with a face that betrayed nothing, a closed, hard boy's face, and Hauke could not look him in the eye.

But the two boys, Bo and Thies, cared nothing for what lay between the fathers. They scuffled and played, as boys do, herded the cattle together, built dams in the ditches, raced each other across the dyke. For them the old story was nothing, a matter of the grown-ups, a silence whose ground they did not know. Sometimes Hauke saw them sitting together on the dyke, his own son and the dead man's son, two small figures against the wide sky, and something contracted in him, and he turned away.

"Leave them," said Antje, when he once spoke of not knowing whether it was right that Bo played with the Feddersen boy. "You won't get the old story out of the children by separating them. Perhaps it's good that they're together. Perhaps it heals, a generation on, what we broke, if only we let it."

"And if it doesn't heal?" said Hauke. "If it only sleeps and wakes later?"

Antje had no answer to that, and neither did Hauke. They let the boys play, and they grew up, the one to be heir of a farm that stood on a guilt, the other to be a hand on that very farm, and neither of them knew it, and over them stood the high sky of the marsh, beneath which everything was visible and nothing was said.

. . .

Chapter 10 - War and Dyke

When the war came, in the summer of 1914, it drew the young men out of the koog, as it drew them everywhere, and the flat land grew emptier still than it already was. The farms stayed with the old, the women, the half-grown, and the dyke, which did not ask whether it was war or peace, the dyke had to be held all the same, with half a crew. Hauke was too old for the front, forty-six, and he was dyke-reeve, and a dyke-reeve was needed where he was. So he stayed and held the dyke, and he held it with the hands that were left: with old men who remembered floods the young had only heard of, with women who dug as well as men, with boys like Bo and Thies who had to lend a hand earlier than their age foresaw. Every repair now became a question of sacrifice: whoever dug at the dyke was missing in the field, and there were too few hands for both.

Thies Feddersen went to the war. He had grown old enough, and he went half voluntarily, half out of defiance, as his father had once half out of defiance warned. Perhaps it was the prospect of escaping the koog, the place where he was the drowned man's son, the hand on the farm that had his father on its conscience. Perhaps it was only what drove all young men that summer, the enthusiasm one no longer understood afterward. Hauke watched him go, with the others, to the station in the county town, and he thought of Momme, who now saw even his only son go off to a war, the war of the gentlemen, for whom a Feddersen counted as little as a Carstens, and yet the Carstens son Bo, too young for the front, counted more in this world

than the Feddersen son, who was old enough to die.

Hunger came with the war, slowly, the way the water came at flood, first imperceptibly, then everywhere. The marsh nourished, it gave corn and cattle, but the state took, requisitioned, and what remained was not enough. Antje ran the economy of scarcity, as she ran everything, with iron precision, and Hauke saw her grow thinner and the children too, and he, as dyke-reeve, had a little more influence, a little more possibility, and he used it, as he always used it: not only for himself.

For Hauke gave. He had never quite stopped giving since the flood, secretly, to the widows, to the poor, to the families of those the war took. And more than to all, he gave, through go-betweens, to the Feddersen widow, whose son now stood in the field, who was alone on her half-warft before the dyke. It did not help him, he knew that; it did not make the breach un-happen, did not give Momme back his life. It was an atonement that calmed only him, not the one to whom the wrong had been done. But he did it all the same, because he could not leave it, because a man who carries such a guilt must do something, even if it is the wrong thing, the insufficient thing.

In that war year a smaller storm tide came, in autumn, nothing against 1906, but enough to call the koog to dyke watch. And the new dyke held. The spot by the sluice, which was now done properly — that Hauke had done first of all after the flood, higher and stronger than everything — that held without difficulty. Hauke stood that night at this very spot, at the spot where Momme had drowned, and the new, strong dyke held the water, and he felt no relief, only a cold bitterness: that he now did, thoroughly and without hesitation, what he had then saved on, and that this Now helped a dead man not at all. He inspected the dyke from then on with the fear of the one who

knows, over-thoroughly, left no spot weak any more, spent no money out of thrift, and the koog praised its conscientious dyke-reeve, and no one knew that this conscientiousness had a dead man at its root.

. . .

Chapter 11 - Antje's Question

The hunger winter of 1917 struck the marsh like everyone, and in that winter Hauke again gave more than he could, of the little the farm had. He carried it away, in the dark, as he had for years, to the Feddersen widow, to other needy ones, and he believed no one noticed, least of all Antje. But Antje noticed everything. She ran the economy, she counted the corn, she knew what was missing. One evening, when he again came home with a half-empty sack, she confronted him. She did not do it loudly. She stood at the hearth, stirring the thin gruel, and said, without turning round: "Who are you atoning for, Hauke?"

It was the same word that another woman in another land in another winter would say to another man, and Hauke did not know it and yet felt it: it was the word that named everything. Atoning. He was silent.

"You carry the corn to the Feddersen widow," said Antje. "For the third time this month. While your own children grow thinner at the table. Why, Hauke?"

"She's alone. Her husband is dead. Her son in the war."

"Her husband is dead." Antje turned round, the spoon in her hand, and her gaunt face was hard in the glow of the hearth-fire. "Yes. Her husband is dead. He stood at the spot by the sluice, Hauke. At the spot you knew would not hold. Of which Momme warned you. Which you should have had done in autumn and did not." She said it calmly, almost without accusation, as if she were reading something long written. "That's what you atone for. Not from pity. From guilt."

It was the first time in eleven years that she spoke it, the one thing that stood between them since the flood night. She had always known it — since the inspection, since Momme's visit in autumn, since the assigning of the watches, since the questioning by the authority at which Hauke kept silent. She had known it and never said it, and now she said it, half, in their own parlour, in the hunger winter, and it lay between them like a stone one finally names.

Hauke could have said everything now. He could have said: Yes. I knew. I saved money, and a man died for it, and I carry it every day. He could have said it to Antje, the only one before whom he need not dissemble, because she knew it anyway. But he did not say it. He said: "It's war, Antje. The widow has no one. Should I let her starve?"

It was no answer, and Antje knew it was none. "Give her what you must," she said and turned back to the hearth. "But don't tell me it's pity. I know you, Hauke. You atone. And atoning makes nothing good. It only makes it bearable for you." She stirred the gruel. "The dead man stays dead, whether you bring the widow corn or not. The only thing you'd owe her is the truth. And that you don't give her. Rather the corn than the truth. That's how you are."

It was the hardest and truest thing she had ever said to him, and Hauke carried it off, as he carried everything off. He went out into the night, before the door of the farmhouse, and stood in the wind that came from the west, and heard the water far behind the dyke. And he understood that Antje now knew fully what he knew, and that she carried it all the same, in silence, that she had settled into the carrying, the way the land settles into being embanked, behind a wall that holds and yet is never quite safe. She had become the silent woman who knows everything. And Hauke knew that he had made

her so, and that too he carried, on top of everything else.

. . .

Chapter 12 - The Dyke Book

The war ended in 1918, and it ended for the marsh as everywhere: in exhaustion, in scarcity, in a stillness that was no relief. Thies Feddersen came back, other than he had gone, more silent, harder, with eyes that had seen too much. He took up his work at the farm again, and Hauke again gave him the good wages, and between the two men lay the same silence as before the war, only grown deeper. In that winter, when everything returned to the old, poorer order, Okke Nissen came to the Carstens warft. The dyke-warden had grown old, over seventy, his hands trembled, and he could no longer serve the office. He came to hand over the dyke book, the old book in which one had entered for a hundred years what happened at the dyke, and which now passed into the dyke-reeve's keeping, as was the custom when a dyke-warden laid down his office.

Okke laid the book on the table, the heavy, leather-bound book, and his trembling hands rested on it a moment. "It's all in there," he said. "A hundred years of dyke. Every flood, every repair, every inspection." He looked at Hauke, and in the leathery, aged face was something Hauke could not interpret and yet understood. "That of nineteen-hundred-six too. The faulty spot. That it was patched and not done. That a warning was given." A pause. "It's in there, Hauke. I entered it, back then, as was my duty. I couldn't leave it out. But I also told no one. That was my sin, if you will. That I entered it and then kept silent."

Hauke looked at the book. "Why did you say nothing? To the authority, back then. You could have —"

"I know what I could have done." Okke took his hands off the book. "I could have brought you down. Split the koog, in the year we had to hold together to survive. I didn't do it. Out of loyalty, I told myself. Out of cowardice, I tell myself now, old as I am and not long for it. It was both." He looked at Hauke. "But the book I wrote as it was. That was the one thing I did right. What you do with it is your affair. You can tear out the page. No one would notice. Or you let it stand."

And Okke went, slowly, with the trembling hands, out into the winter, and Hauke stayed alone with the book.

That night he opened it, by the light of the lamp, and leafed until he found the page. There it stood, in Okke's old, orderly hand: the date, the faulty spot by the sluice, the note that it had been patched and not thoroughly done, that the dyke-reeve had been warned. Black on white, the truth that no one knew, that no one had read except Okke and now Hauke.

He held the book nearer the lamp. He could have torn out the page. It would have been sensible; it would have erased the last trace, the last testimony. He took the page between his fingers. And then he left it. He left it standing, the page, the entry, the truth, and he did not quite know why, only that it was impossible for him to destroy it, as it had been impossible for him to speak the truth. Perhaps it was cowardice, like Okke's. Perhaps it was something else, something that was almost hope: that one distant day there would be someone who opened the book, who read, who asked, and that then there should be something that answered, when all the mouths that now kept silent had long fallen quiet. He could not say it. But he could let

the entry stand, for the one who would come.

He closed the book and laid it in the chest, with the other farm papers, and outside it was still, quite still, because frost had covered the land and even the water at the sluice had come to rest. Bo, now ten, slept in the next room, and in the morning he would go again to the field and to the dyke, the boy who would one day inherit the book, with the chest, with the entry, without knowing what he inherited. And Hauke sat long by the light of the lamp and looked at the chest in which the truth now lay, enclosed, kept, passed on, and he thought that one does not get rid of a guilt by walling it up, as little as one gets rid of the sea by building a dyke. Both remain. Both press. And one day both find a spot where one has saved.

. . .

Chapter 13 - Inflation and Land

The money died in the early twenties, and it died in the marsh too, although the marsh was far from the cities where one carried the notes in a washing basket. Hauke had saved, in the years as dyke-reeve, in the good harvest years; he had set aside what he could, a cushion for the farm, for Bo's future. And it evaporated, almost overnight, became worthless paper, as everywhere. ~~But unlike a man in the city who had nothing but his money,~~ Hauke had the land. And the land remained. It could not be devalued, not printed worthless overnight; it lay where it lay, fat and fertile, the won land of the marsh, and with it the stretch that had fallen to him out of the flood, through the new dyke line, the land that had once bordered the Feddersens. While the money of the rise evaporated, the ground of the rise remained: the land he had gained where Momme lost.

Antje saw him sitting at the table with the worthless notes, and she said the sentence Hauke did not forget, soberly, almost gently: "Land doesn't lie, but it doesn't forget either." She meant the money that vanished and the land that remained. And she meant the other, the land on which their prosperity stood, the stretch that had come out of the flood. She meant both, and both knew it.

In that winter the Feddersen widow died. She died poor, on the half-warft before the dyke, in the land that was worth nothing any more, of the lung, of poverty, of the years of privation. She was not an old woman, but she looked like one. Thies, returned from the war, now stood alone, the last Feddersen, without father, without mother,

without land, a labourer on others' farms, and his face had grown hard and closed like the water in frost.

Hauke went to the burial. He could have stayed away; no one expected the dyke-reeve at the grave of the poor widow whose husband had drowned at his spot. But he went, because he could not do otherwise, because something in him had to stand at this grave. He stood at the back, at the edge of the small mourning party, and at the front stood Thies, alone, upright, in his threadbare clothes, and did not look across, until the grave was nearly closed. Then Thies raised his head and looked across the heads to where Hauke stood, and their eyes met.

Thies said no word. He said the loudest word one can say by saying no word. In his gaze lay everything: the knowledge he had from his father, of the faulty spot, the warning, the not-being-heard; the accusation that never came to court, because there was no proof except an entry in a book that lay in a chest; and a bitter, hard satisfaction that Hauke had come, that Hauke needed to come, that the dyke-reeve stood at the grave of the widow whose husband had guarded his spot. Then Thies turned away.

Hauke went home through the cold marsh, and the worthless notes rustled in his pocket, and beneath his feet lay the land that remained, the won land, his land, and he thought of Antje's word: land doesn't lie, but it doesn't forget either. The money was gone, the wage of the rise, evaporated. But the land had remained, the ground of the rise, and with it the guilt that lay in the soil, firmer than any money, un-devaluable, inheritable. And before the dyke, in the abandoned stretch, lay the sunken Feddersen warft beneath the water that came and went twice a day and let nothing be forgotten.

. . .

Chapter 14 - The Old Dyke-Reeve

Hauke grew old, as Okke had grown old, and the time came when he had to give up the office. He had held it nearly thirty years, longer than most, and he had held it well, everyone said so: a conscientious dyke-reeve who left no spot weak, who would rather over-repair than under, who never saved at the dyke. They did not know where this conscientiousness came from, and Hauke did not say so. Bo strove for the office. He was a man now, in his mid-twenties, soon to marry, and he wanted to be what his father had been, and more: he wanted to be greater. The ambition Hauke had seen sprouting in the child had now fully blossomed, and it was uncanny to Hauke, because he knew it so exactly.

There was a last dyke inspection that Hauke and Bo walked together, the old dyke-reeve and the coming one, section by section, and Hauke showed his son everything, every spot, every weakness, every history of the dyke. And when they came to the spot by the sluice, the spot that was now for thirty years the strongest of the whole dyke, because Hauke had made it higher and firmer after the flood than everything else — there Hauke halted, and something in him wanted to speak.

"This spot," he said. "Bo. This spot you must always keep an eye on."

"It's the strongest on the whole dyke," said Bo. "One can see that."

"Yes. Now it is." Hauke looked at the spot, at the firm, high mountain beneath which the water lay, at which a man had once

drowned. "It wasn't always the strongest. There was a time when it was the weakest. There —" He faltered. The sentence lay on his tongue, the whole sentence, the truth: There the dyke broke, because I had not had the spot done, and Momme Feddersen drowned, and on that our farm stands. It lay on his tongue, at the place itself, before the son who would inherit the office and with the office the responsibility for the spot.

"There what?" asked Bo.

Hauke looked at the son, the ambitious, capable son who knew nothing, and he could not get it out. "There it was weak," he said. "Long ago. Hold the dyke, Bo. Nothing more. Hold it well. Never save at the dyke. That's all I can give you."

It was all, and it was too little, and neither knew it, the one because he did not know what was missing, the other because he could not say it. They walked the inspection to its end, and Bo was elected dyke-reeve the same year, young for the office, as Hauke had been young, and Hauke watched him take the office with a mixture of pride and fear that he could explain to no one.

Hauke died a few years later, in bed, in winter, an old man who could no longer walk the dyke. Bo sat with him in the last days, and once, in a clear moment, Hauke reached for the son's hand and said: "Bo. There is something you must know. About the flood, back then. About Momme Feddersen. About the spot —"

And then his strength left him, or his courage, or both, and the clear moment passed, and Hauke sank back and said only: "Hold the dyke. And the book — the book in the chest —" No more came. The sentence he had not said for thirty years stayed unfinished even now, at the edge of death, as it had stayed unfinished at the spot by the sluice. Hauke Carstens died with his guilt, almost whole, and took

the essential with him, and left behind only the breach, unnamed, inherited, and the dyke book in the chest, with the entry no one read.

Bo did not understand the last words. The book in the chest — he found it, leafed through it, saw a hundred years of dyke history, floods, repairs, inspections, and he found the entry of 1906 too, read it, and did not understand it, because he did not know what it pointed to; for Bo it was an old entry about an old spot that had long been the strongest. He shut the book and laid it back in the chest, and he inherited his father's silence, completely, without knowing the ground of it, and laid it, without wanting to, over his own children, who would come.

. . .

Chapter 15 - The Hereditary Farm

Bo led the farm into a time that was changing, faster than the marsh was used to. In the early thirties came first the crisis, the collapse of prices, the hardship even on the land, and then came the new time, with flags and promises and a law that seemed made precisely for the farmers of the marsh: the Reich Hereditary Farm Law. The hereditary farm. It meant the farm was indivisible, unsellable, unmortgageable, that it passed undivided to a single heir, that no bank could take it, no creditor. For a man like Bo, who set the farm above all else, who wanted to increase and hold it at any price, it was a promise he could scarcely resist: protection, security, honour, the farmer as bearer of the people, the soil as sacred. It fit everything Bo was and wanted to be, and he threw in his lot with those who promised it, without asking long what else he was making common cause with.

He had married Grete, a farmer's daughter from the neighbouring koog, clear and incorruptible like Antje once, and Grete saw the new time with other eyes than Bo. She mistrusted the flags, the promises, the noise. But she held it back, for the children's sake, and because a woman in the marsh had little say against a man who had the office and the farm and now the party behind him.

Thies Feddersen was still there, the last Feddersen, landless, a labourer, now at Bo's, as he had been at Hauke's. The old humiliation went on under a new sign: where the hereditary farm law raised and protected the farmer, it left the landless precisely what he was,

without prospect, without land, for a hereditary farm could only be held by one who already had land. Thies saw Bo rise in the new time, as he had seen Hauke rise after the flood, and his face betrayed nothing, and he worked and was silent.

Bo took over from his dead father the dyke book too, which lay in the chest. He took it out, once, leafed through it, saw the entry of 1906, which he had already seen once and not understood. This time he read it more closely: the faulty spot by the sluice, patched and not done, the dyke-reeve warned. And for a moment an inkling brushed him, a chill, a connection that did not quite fit — his father, the office, the flood in which Momme Feddersen drowned, Thies's father, who now worked for him. But Bo was not a man who pursued inklings that were uncomfortable. He shut the book, laid it back, and told himself it was an old entry about an old spot that had long been the strongest on the dyke. The father had made it so strong precisely for that reason. What should be amiss in it.

So Bo overlooked the truth that was put into his hand, because he could not interpret it and would not, and laid the book back in the chest, and with it the guilt he now carried without knowing it. And over the marsh flew the new flags, and the hereditary farm law made the Carstens farm untouchable, grown out of a flood, founded on a concealed breach, and no one asked where the prosperity came from, least of all Bo, who now increased it under the protection of the new time.

. . .

Chapter 16 - Blood and Soil

The slogans of the new time seemed made for the marsh. Blood and soil, it was called, the farmer as the root of the people, the soil as sacred, the land as the inheritance of the forebears. For a farmer whose family had wrested the same soil from the sea for five generations, that did not sound like a lie but like a confirmation of what he believed anyway: that the land was everything, that the farm counted, that the farmer was something special. Bo let himself be carried by these words, because they flattered him, because they gave him what his ambition hungered for: the feeling of being something. He became local farm leader. It was no great office, but it was power, small power over the neighbours, over the delivery quota, over the distribution, and Bo misunderstood it, as his father had once half misunderstood the dyke-reeve's office: as a rise, a duty, what was due to one who was capable. He did not see, or did not want to see, what he carried along by holding the office, what system he served by keeping lists and collecting quotas and putting himself on the side of the loud.

The first severities came, quietly at first. A neighbour who had talked too openly was fetched and came back changed. A pedlar in the county town, a Jew, was one day no longer there. One learned to lower the gaze, to see nothing, to say nothing — the old art of the marsh that Bo had inherited from his father without knowing he had inherited it, this art of looking away, of protecting one's own, of holding oneself out, while others fell. Bo looked away, as Hauke had looked away, and called it reason, called it duty for the farm, for the

family.

Grete brought a child into the world that year, a son, and for one summer happiness seemed possible: the farm, the children, the fertile marsh, the garden behind the warft where Grete grew beans and cabbage. It was a real happiness, not a pretended one, a summer of sun and growth. But over the happiness lay what lay over everything in that time: the flags, the slogans, the war that was not yet there and already stood on the horizon, the way a storm tide can be read in the weather days before.

And beneath the happiness lay the soil that bore the guilt. Bo did not know it. He stood on the dyke, on an evening in that last summer of peace, and looked over his land, the won land, the fat, fertile land of the marsh, and before the dyke lay the abandoned foreland, under water, with the sunken Feddersen warft that no one saw any more, that only the old people knew. Bo saw the calm water over the foreland and thought nothing of it, thought of the harvest, of the farm, of the son who slept. He did not know that he stood on a guilt half a century old, and that he would carry it on into a time darker than anything the marsh had known, and that the water, which lay so calm over the old foreland, waited patiently, as it always waited, for a time not yet born.

Behind him, in the chest, lay the dyke book with the entry he had overlooked. Before him lay the water over the taken land. And in him, unknown, lay the breach his father had made, and now rode with him, with Bo Carstens, local farm leader and dyke-reeve, into the war and into his own guilt, which was yet to come and would so resemble the first that it was as if the water had written it a second time.

Über dieses Buch

The Reclaimed Land - Reclaiming the Land

Ein Schreib-Experiment von aban news, Kapitel für Kapitel mit Claude Opus verfasst und redigiert.

Riedmatt, der Stausee und alle Figuren sind erfunden; Ähnlichkeiten mit realen Orten oder Personen sind Zufall.

© 2026 aban news · Allen Chour, Belp (CH) · abannews.com